



Yoga works whatever your age. The poses stimulate the hormone-secreting endocrine system and help to keep your muscles toned. Yoga's a great stress-buster, too.

and will respond more quickly to change. Make this a time to establish good exercise and eating habits.

Your 30s Between the ages of 28 and 32 is usually when most of us realize that our body “suddenly” isn’t the same as it once was. Research has revealed that we naturally lose around 5lb (2kg) of lean body mass and replace it with fat every decade starting from our late 20s. Even if you weigh the same as you did in your 20s, chances are that fat has replaced some of your lean muscle.

Most gyms can take a body-fat reading, or you can buy a machine for home use. If you’re female and aged between 20 and 39, a healthy body-fat reading is 21–33 percent; between 40 and 59, the reading should be 23–34 percent. If you are carrying extra fat, the longer it’s there, the harder it

is to get rid of it. I’m a great believer in aerobic exercise as the best fat stripper, so whatever workout you do, work aerobically in it, which means maintaining a steady pace for a long time.

If you haven’t already started resistance training, now’s a good time since your bones are already starting to become less dense and this, later in life, can lead to osteoporosis and fractures. Resistance training helps protect you against osteoporosis by slowing down the loss of minerals from your bones while building muscle, too.

Your 40s Whether or not you believe that the 40s are the new 30s, with all the resources we have at our disposal, there’s no doubt that you can continue to feel and look great.

You may now need to start toning down your high-impact cardio (running and jogging) to low-impact (brisk walking, rowing, or using a cross trainer) to protect your knees. When walking, keep the aerobic pressure up by pumping your arms as you go or by holding weights. You may also want to work your core muscles, to keep—or encourage the return of—your nice flat tummy. Try targeted stomach exercises like crunches or planks, or go to a Pilates class. You should also continue—or start—resistance training exercise.

Also make sure you incorporate stretches in your exercise program. These not only increase range of movement, but will also help tone your muscles. Yoga or Pilates are great for stretching.

Your 50s If you’ve reached your 50s and never exercised, remember, it’s not too late, even though your metabolism will be slowing down (see p.174). If you’re a beginner, start by joining a gym and getting your fitness assessed so you’re sure to work safely and within your capabilities.

Continue—or start—resistance training to protect your bones, and do some low-impact cardio such as working on a rowing machine, swimming, or walking, especially uphill.

Finally, don’t forget those stretches. If you’re lucky, at this stage in your life, you may have more time for yourself, so you can focus on keeping your body in tip-top condition, both now and for many healthy decades to come.